

Citicorp Center the toast of New York: ARCHITECTURE

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Lower part of Citicorp complex is a shopping center made up largely of restaurants focusing on a tree-filled atrium. Architect was Hugh Stubbins of Cambridge.

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Citicorp Center is a smasheroo, no question about it. It's all New York. Broadway-glamorous, showbiz-spectacular.

To begin with, at 915 feet it's the eighth tallest building in the world. And you can't miss noticing how high it is because its tower doesn't even start until it's 215 feet up. It sits on four stilts that are higher than Niagara Falls.

There are so many restaurants in this complex that even *Gourmet* magazine is glutted, referring in this month's issue to "restaurant-clogged Citicorp Center." There's a scenic sunken plaza, with its own direct subway entrance. There's even a large church.

And you aren't likely to ignore the shiny, tinsel-town aluminum of which everything is built so different from the sedate browns and grays of the nearby Seagram and CBS buildings and those other black-tie, sobersided towers.

For dessert, there's an enormous atrium, a multi-story skylit indoor

ARCHITECTURE/ROBERT CAMPBELL

space floored with a forest of trees among which I thought I heard the recorded sounds of twittering birds, until I realized I was instead listening to the pleasant, cricket-like squeaks of the aluminum panels rubbing together in a high wind.

Citicorp reminds you not of the financially crippled and vandalized New York of today but rather of the New York of your childhood, when your parents took you to Radio City and Chinatown and the top of the Empire State building. It has that kind of glitter, that indispensable flashiness. Designed by a Boston architect, it's the most New York building I can think of. It's a winner.

The architect, Hugh Stubbins, also did the recently-opened Federal Reserve Building here, but Citicorp is much better. The reason is simple: after a generation of office towers that were nothing BUT office towers, and which looked like vertical graph-paper at that,

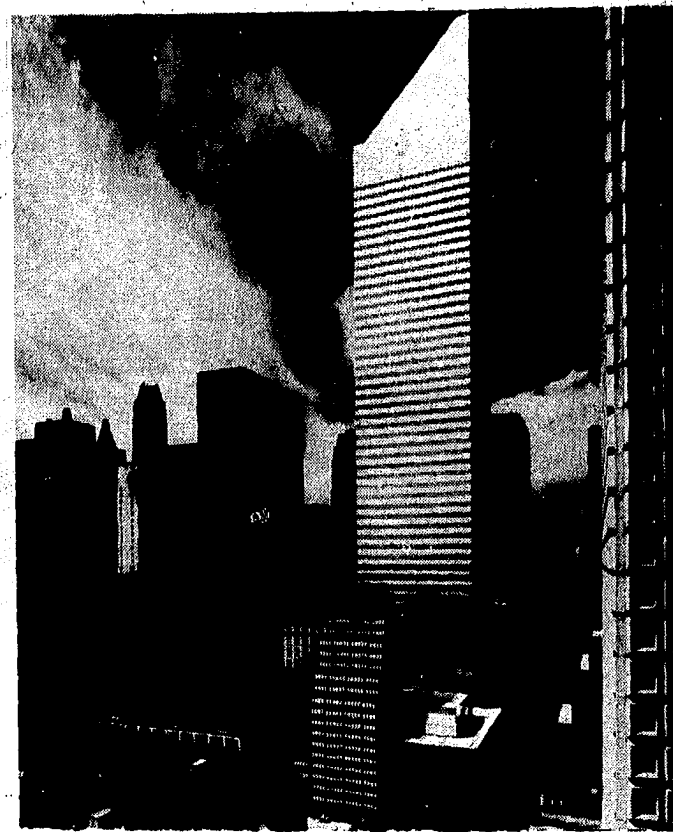
Citicorp returns to the kind of multiple mix of activities that characterized the office towers of the twenties and thirties, especially Rockefeller Center with its shops, cafes and theaters.

Citicorp press releases take credit for the multi-use concept. But it's really the brainchild of the old Office of Midtown Planning, a group of ex-Mayor Lindsay's whiz-kids whose ideas also created the nearby mixed-use Galleria and Olympic Tower. The planners' concept was that you could get developers to include such amenities as shops, arcades and apartments in their office towers if you gave them, in exchange, the right to build more office space than zoning would otherwise allow.

Citicorp took full advantage of this so-called "incentive zoning," even to the extent of proposing, at an early stage, to top the tower off with an artificial hill of apartments. The apartments were dropped, but the slant-top configuration remained because it

made the building look different. Eventually it occurred to someone to use the slope as a solar collector, so it was redesigned to face south, but as yet collectors have not been installed.

I once worked nearby, and I'm sure people will miss the old Save Mor drugstore and Carroll's Pub, the Barney Stone bar, Deli City and the American and Foreign magazine center, the Lexington Sandwich Shoppe, the Pizza Plaza, Cafe Chauveron, the Hippopotamus nightclub and the host of other places that occupied this intricately small-scaled, richly diverse block. Some will mourn the passing of the few surviving townhouses and the man who, in one of them, was paying \$6.90 a week for his room with towels. For \$40 million, Citicorp bought everyone out in a classic land assemblage that was a story in itself, one told by *New York* magazine a few years ago. A townhouse owner held out for and got \$815,000. A doctor's co-operative refused to sell and finally merged its stock with Citicorp's stock in a deal that gave each of 40 doctor-owners \$30 worth of Citicorp stock for each dollar of his medical stock.



Overall view shows Citicorp Center's tower rising 915 feet above Lexington avenue.

But this is one time we need not lament the passing of small businesses muscled out by a corporate monster. Though many will still prefer the homely distractions of the old block, and the appealing fact that people actually lived there, though some may think Citicorp by contrast is all bigness and flash, it offers a great deal in return.

Like Faneuil Hall Marketplace, Citicorp Center's shops are a "theme" complex. It's called The Market and it's resolutely focused on food. There are at least 11 restaurants or chic-food boutiques, many of them opening onto the indoor atrium. On an upper level, also surrounding the atrium, is a vast and colorful Conran's, the modern British home-furnishing store now also being proposed for Harvard Square. Cafe tables are interspersed among the trees.

As for the church that occupies a corner of Citicorp Center, it's St. Peter's Lutheran.

It was largely the need to give the new church some headroom that caused

Citicorp's office tower to be raised on four huge stilts. The church is simple and pleasant in design, though its granite exterior doesn't complement the aluminum surroundings.

The church contains a large sanctuary and also a small chapel. The chapel has fine sculptures by Louise Nevelson next to the altar. In keeping with the relaxed church-and-commerce atmosphere of the whole place, the chapel's other detail consists largely of air-handling grilles, sprinkler heads, junction-box caps and an aluminum window. An all-seeing Deity is represented by a security camera on one wall that clicks every time you move. The overall effect is unpretentious and charming.

A great deal more could be said about this important building complex. It's certainly chic, it's grandiose, and it practically shouts money. It probably won't please the adherents of any particular school of architecture. But it has the virtues that count. It's theatrical and self-advertising and alive in a way that's healthy in midtown Manhattan.